ONE LAST CARESS

Psychological Horror / Tragic Romance

Let me tell you one last thing about killing.

It came naturally to me.

It didn't take long to learn how to lure someone in, how to erase the evidence, how to dispose of what remained. Once you understand what you're doing, it becomes remarkably difficult to stop.

But eventually, like everything else, even that became boring.

The excitement faded.

The rush disappeared.

And I became numb again.

So I stopped for a while.

I thought perhaps I needed something new.

That was when I decided to get a tattoo.

I asked one of my friends to come with me. The design I'd chosen was the skull logo of the Misfits, based on the old *Crimson Ghost* serial.

The drive there wasn't boring, at least. My friend was good company. We spent most of the journey listening to my music, and at one point she laughed and asked how someone as gentle and pleasant as me could possibly enjoy songs filled with so much death, murder and horror.

I laughed with her.

I found the question genuinely amusing.

There is something frightening about realizing how little you truly know the people around you.

That was when I saw her.

Melanie.

When I returned home that night, I couldn't sleep.

I lay awake thinking about her.

About her eyes.

About the strange way she'd looked at me.

And about how, for a few brief moments, something inside me had felt less empty.

By the end of the following week, I knew everything I needed to know about her.

Her name was Melanie.

Her hair was naturally jet black, although she'd dyed it burgundy. She was about five foot eight, with ocean-blue eyes touched by flecks of burnt brown.

Her father had been a police officer. Her mother had worked as a waitress. She had an older sister and a younger brother.

She studied German.

I even followed her long enough to learn where she lived.

Strangely, however, she seemed to know she was being watched.

That interested me.

Getting close to her would require patience. One mistake and I would ruin everything.

So I waited.

The opportunity finally came at the midyear party.

I made sure to stay close to one of my female friends because she knew someone who knew Melanie. It gave me a perfectly natural reason to be near her.

Nothing suspicious.

Nothing strange.

Just Ash.

Friendly, charming, harmless Ash.

When the moment came, Melanie and I started talking.

We spoke a little German. I'd learned enough of it specifically for her, although I didn't tell her that.

Eventually, I asked her to dance.

She agreed.

She didn't look particularly enthusiastic about it.

Still, she stayed.

As we moved together, I leaned toward her and whispered in German:

"Your eyes are brighter than the sun."

She stared directly at me.

"You don't fool me."

For perhaps the first time in my life, I didn't immediately know what to say.

So I smiled.

Played confused.

"What do you mean?"

"You're not the person you pretend to be."

The smile remained on my face.

She didn't look away.

"I can tell. And if we're going to be friends—even just friends—I want to know who you actually are."

I studied her.

People had called me charming.

Kind.

Funny.

Polite.

Some had trusted me almost immediately.

Others had told me things they wouldn't tell people they'd known for years.

Everyone saw what I wanted them to see.

But Melanie was standing in front of me, looking straight through it.

I smiled at her.

"You wouldn't want to know me."

"Why?"

"Because what's underneath isn't very pretty."

She waited.

"It's ugly, Melanie. The kind of ugly that makes your skin crawl."

Instead of stepping away, she smiled back.

"However bad it is, I'd rather have that than this mask."

I said nothing.

"I can tolerate almost anything," she continued. "What I can't tolerate is dishonesty and hypocrisy."

And that was how our story began.

Afterward, I listened to the song we'd danced to again and again.

I messaged her when I woke up.

Again while I ate breakfast.

Again after my lectures.

Again in the locker room before practice.

And once more before we went to sleep.

Our relationship developed absurdly fast, probably because we spent most of every day talking to each other.

Whenever I had time, I went to see her at her college.

We talked about everything.

Life.

Religion.

Science.

The things people are supposed to consider important.

Then we'd spend just as long discussing completely meaningless things—my favourite colour, something she'd bought that afternoon, whatever happened to cross our minds.

None of it felt meaningless when it came from her.

I belonged in her eyes.

Because when she looked at me, I felt alive.

When she looked at me, I felt whole.

There was only one problem.

Melanie had asked to meet the person behind the mask.

And sooner or later, I was going to have to decide whether I could actually let her.